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The Deterioration of American Institutional Trust

Trust is an emotion that has been an integral aspect of human relationships and cooperation and forms the necessary back bone of what builds societies. It is inherently a social emotion because its origin of expression comes from cooperation with other parties. However, trust is seemingly something that is in short supply in recent times as feelings of distrust grow towards the American government, and perhaps more unsettlingly, the American people are losing trust amongst each other. Reasons offered up as an explanation for this decline varies spanning from indirect causes such economic conditions to more direct causes such as direct historic events leading to immediate reductions in trust. However, the explanation for the deterioration of trust within American society may not be so simple as to be explained with a simple cause and effect because the way trust is perceived today has shifted from how it was in the past. This high level of trust itself is a somewhat new phenomena, and its origin deriving from changes in trust can give insight into why deterioration is occurring.

It may be easy to assume that such a change to the emotion of trust occurred during the greatest shifts in public trust as with the common narratives such as distrust growing the Vietnam war, but that does not necessarily hold true. Time and again, narratives written by historians and those with political interests are found not to represent the reality of what occurred or what they believed by evidence of action or by polls. For example, as much as the “Red Scare” and Senator

McCarthy was talked about when discussing the 1940's to 1950's, "Only twice in these years (April and June 1954) did as many as 10 percent of the voters identify "Communists in the United States" or "Communists in the government" as the nation's most important problem" (Thelen, 1976). For this reason and especially in the case where there is little evidence that can be found, claims must be examined closely to find an accurate picture of emotional history as is the case with trust. It is simple to have preconceived notions of what emotions were like in the past and mistakenly assume that the state of current emotions represent them, but in many cases that is simply just not true based on evidence. Examining the conditions and trends of trust before World War 2 and after show that the change in the perspective of trust may have occurred during the war, compounding the trust built from Franklin D. Roosevelt New Deal with the solidarity promoted and gained from the war to propel the United States of America into a high trust society. However, this high trust society that has been built relies on a trust that is in decline, and the problems of being a high trust society with low trust have begun rearing their head.

The "Simple" Definition of Trust

The definition of trust is multifaceted as the context of the emotion differs between different types of relationships between parties. Definitions vary in a variety of different ways when written about in literature, which results in definitions that are similar but not quite the same due to the required narrowness to properly describe any singular feeling of trust. The reason for this is that trust is primarily a social emotion that is dependent on the interaction between a trustee and trustor, which creates a complex layer of relation and intended goals between trustees and trustors by which trust is ultimately based on the. However, there are a few commonalities exist between each of the definitions of trust for which a more generalized

concept of the emotion of modern trust can be made. For example, Kuwabara describes trust as, “the interpersonal (person-to-person) and relational (person-to-relation) components of solidarity that promotes cooperation and commitment in exchange relations”, while Putnam describes it in more detail as an emotion that has two forms: thick and thin. Thick trust in their definition appears when two people with an emotional relation to each other are certain that the other will follow through on promises and usually occurs between close social relations such as family and friends. Thin trust on the other hand extends past a person’s own emotional network and into community of strangers based on reputation and norms for following through with promises (Kuwabara et al., 2014; Putnam, 2000).

How they both define trust is subtly different due to the differing contexts that they are using the word in which necessitate narrow definitions to be accurate, but at their core they are very similar in concept in that their underlying assumptions for trust are the same. First and foremost, the emotion of trust cannot exist within an individual vacuum such as other emotions can (e.g. happiness, fear, pride, etc.). There must be a trustee for a trustor to feel trust towards, and this trustee may be a single person or a grouping of people related to each other in some aspect but not necessarily directly personal. Second, trust is felt in response to a need for cooperation. Its impetus for expression comes from needing to gauge risk and reward for attempting cooperation with a party. Third, trust is a continuous and everyday emotion that develops from the actions of individuals or actions attributed to a grouped community. Long term, the feeling of the emotion may be fleeting, but how it is felt, whether with great confidence or none, depends on the aggregate actions by a party built over time. Thus, I define trust to be in a loose definition, a continuous emotion that arises from the social relation and interactions

between two parties, whether they are individuals or groups, such to facilitate cooperation in a society based on the confidence that an expectation will be fulfilled.

Stage Growth Model of Trust

There exist multiple varieties of trust depending on who the trustee is. Differences in what kind of trust is felt depends on the relation between a trustor and trustee, but four general main groupings of trust types exist as defined by Latusek and Olejniczak assembled from loosely related prior definitions: relational trust, organizational trust, institutional trust, and finally public trust. The first of these, relational trust, is a trust based on emotional ties and built from long-standing relationships with people most relevant to an individual such as family and friends. The distinction it has from the other types of trust in that it is highly exclusive in expression and is based upon the context of close personal relationships and prior experiences of interaction with others not generally feasible nor applicable to larger groups. Next, organizational trust is an indirect trust formed with a group that an individual is a member of or interacts with closely, and it is both less personal and less direct as the scale of organizations makes it increasingly more difficult to do so. Thus, individuals of an organization apply this organizational trust to all of the members of the organization that they do not have a personal relationship with when needing to cooperate. Institutional trust is quite similar to organizational trust but with the difference is of scale. This trust goes beyond individual organizations and groups and is applied to the body that facilitates cooperation between groups and represents them. An example of a trustee that would be an institution is the national government of a country. Finally, public trust, also known as generalized trust, is the widest scale of trust that an individual person is capable of experiencing. Rather than a trust to any formal body such as a group or government, it is broadly expressed towards people who do not have any relation with an individual whether they be a foreigner, a

passing salesman, or simply a random person walking down a street. This kind of emotional trust is what people interact with most routinely and is the most widely impactful type of trust for individuals.

Now that trust has been defined and the types identified, a bigger question emerges of how to reconcile the relation between these assorted types of trust. To answer this, Latusek and Olejniczak propose a dynamic model of trust development that moves upwards in stages which incorporates the different types of trust as the stages of trust development from relational trust as the first stage to eventually public trust at the final stage. All societies, whether they are low or high trust, have a base of people that do their business cooperating with close friends and families as their first stage. This leads to highly positive trust and great levels of cooperation, but it stifles growth and does not allow for cooperation with outsiders. The next stage, organizational trust, comes from the expansion of cooperation to include those with shared views and values in an organization who are then all united by the formalization of rules and processes. Once a critical point of trust growth is reached again, the next stage for trust becomes institutional trust. In this stage, an institution such as a government becomes a necessary third party to be trusted to manage inter-organizational trust to ease cooperation between them. After all the other stages are maintained and trust continues to grow, we reach the final stage of trust growth, which effects public trust. Individuals in societies of this stage have experienced all other stages of trust with sufficiently low rates of trust violations, which makes them able to extend their trust towards the entirety of a society full of strangers to an extent. This stage is the most uncommon and difficult to maintain type of trust, and only after a collective society reaches this stage do they transition into a high trust society (LATUSEK & OLEJNICZAK, 2016).

Though all of these types of trust are important, the key area of trust most important in the decline in American institutional trust is, unsurprisingly, institutional trust. Though organizational and public trust will be discussed briefly in relation to institutional trust and the effect they have and have had on one another other, the chief focus when analyzing the historical change in the emotion of trust will be towards institutional trust.

Trust: Past and Present as an Emotion

It is simple to determine when trust began its visible decline because that is quite well recorded and, as Stearns notes in his article An Emotional America, it seems to have occurred in the early 1960's (Stearns, 2018). However, the visible outcomes of change do not necessarily present the whole picture about the development of that change and trust is no different in that regard. A decline is a result of an effect and an effect requires a cause. This decline is certainly indicative of a change that has occurred but a decline itself is usually not the cause of that change. For that, we must look back at the past and present to achieve a proper perspective of change based on ration that is blind to present and past bias.

Using a Google Ngam for the word "trust", the usage of "trust" shows up as remarkably consistent throughout the 19th century with dips and rises throughout the century, but in the 20th century, a significant dip in usage lasts for an unusually long period spanning multiple decades in the mid-20th century (*Google Books Ngram Viewer*, n.d.). This suggests something occurred during that period which may have caused people to become hesitant to use the word in writing, but this does not mean people were necessarily lacking in trust. On the contrary, this period was actually one of the highest points of trust in America with regards for the American government as can be seen from a correlation between one of the lowest frequency of use years 1963 and peak of public trust in government during Kennedy's presidency in 1963 ("Public Trust in

Government," 2019). This deviation in the usage of the term and the high frequency of feeling positive trust in government seems incredibly odd which suggests that there may have been some catalyst for a shift in the state of trust as an emotion during this period of time.

When attempting to look into this discrepancy and trying to compare the trust of the present to trust of the old, a problem emerges in that, there simply is not much scholarly discussion of trust from sources prior to the mid-20th century. Notably, Barabalet observes that trust as an emotion begins to be explored in more detail by psychologists interested in interpersonal trust starting approximately around the mid-20th century, which has led in part to our modern understanding of trust. A variety of different fields began to research trust after this point such as in sociology and management research. A Google Scholar search for the word trust reveals that the number of publications that refer to trust in their title began to grow exponentially from a moderate 46,500 items found in the 1960's to 2,030,000 items in the 2000's. Furthermore, literature prior to the 1950's was by in large not referring to the emotion trust but rather legal trusts, which somewhat hides the true disparity between the amount of understanding of trust as an emotion in the past as compared to today (Barbalet, 2019). This lack of interest prior to the 1950's suggests that there was something developing with trust that would lead to an interest in it.

A source where this development is discernable are polls that contain questions about trust. Polls that have historically recorded trust levels for both general trust and institutional trust only begin to start including questions about trust after this mid-20th century period, which coincides, with the beginning of earnest academic exploration of trust further indicating that something changed that captured the interest of both pollsters and researchers. The Pew Research Center only began their polls for public trust in government in 1958, and the Gallop Organization

began their public trust polls following shortly afterwards in 1964 ("Public Trust in Government," 2019; National Survey of Attitudes, Hopes, and Fears, Question 56, 1964). One of the earliest reliable polls for institutional and public trust comes from the National Opinion Research Center (NORC), and their polls show a telling trend that is indicative of a change in the perception and prevalence of trust in America. Starting from the earliest available poll in 1942 in the middle of American involvement in World War 2, the answer to the question, "Do you think most people can be trusted?" receives a response of 66% of people saying "Yes", and as time progresses the percentage of "Yes" replies increase further. The percentage of "Yes" replies increase to 75% in 1957 and peaks at 77% in 1963 and holding in 1964. These results when overlaid over the Pew Center results for trust in government show a curious correlation between public trust and the institutional trust in government with the results of the Pew Poll being 73% in 1958 and 77% in 1964 which supports the intertwining of public and institutional trust. However, a precipitous decline in trust occurs shortly afterwards seen in both polls that coincide with the U.S. entrance into the Vietnam War (*NORC Survey: Foreign Affairs Question 22*, 1942; *NORC Survey: Foreign Affairs Question 36*, 1957; *NORC Survey: Foreign Affairs Question 127*, 1963; *NORC Survey: Foreign Affairs Question 160*, 1964; "Public Trust in Government," 2019).

In aggregate, this trend in polling evidence and dates of the earliest trust polls, the timely beginnings of research on trust, and the corresponding decline in the usage of the word trust point towards the change in trust for America to become its current form during and shortly after America's involvement in World War 2. In large part this change may have been by spurred on by the solidarity from World War 2, which as Hosking suggests, "generated widespread public consciousness of the need for mutual solidarity within society, including between rich and poor"

(Hosking, 2019). As mutual solidarity increased, a wide spread growth in trust lead way to the maturation of institutional trust and public trust leading America to become the high trust society that it is today where strong public trust prevails between interactions.

Prior to World War 2, the past landscape for the emotion of trust was seemingly in a different state than it is in the present. Though there be little data directly about trust for the period, information exists about opinions and actions that correlate to trust today can be used to get a sense of how trust fit into American society in the past. One such comparison point is a paradox that does not hold in the present condition of trust but held without a doubt during the depression era before World War 2. Taking a look at the current opinions of the United States federal government compared to the trust in that government, there is a clear present link between public opinion and approval of federal government with 74% disapproving of the government and 25% of people having trust in the government ("How a Different America Responded to the Great Depression," 2010; "Public Trust in Government," 2019). However, when observing the circumstances around the Great Depression, this link does not appear to exist. Consider the fact that Rev. Charles Coughlin was able to gather and hold an audience of 30 million Americans in his radio broadcasts during his weekly criticisms of Franklin D. Roosevelt's policies and the federal government's handling of the depression. This seems to suggest that there was a lack of trust during pre-World War 2 period in stark contrast to the high amount of trust afterwards (Hetherington et al., n.d.). This kind of lack of trust would lead to a lack of approval for federal government actions today by modern standards of the trust, but that modern perspective did not hold during this period. In spite of this apparent lack of trust, support and approval for federal government action in support of New Deal policies do not appear to be linked very closely at all if modern standards of trust are applied to the situation. 54% of polled

Americans expressed that they would want the same spending pattern to be followed again if there was another depression ("How a Different America Responded to the Great Depression," 2010). This modern linkage between opinion and approval that did not exist in the past seems to suggest that as a result of becoming a high trust society. Americans of the present have seemingly become more reliant on trust when interacting with institutions like the Federal Government, whereas in the past trust in the government was not believed to be needed for it to perform.

This concept of reliance on trust is a key differentiating factor of trust in the past that changed after World War 2, and it is somewhat arguably one of the keys to America's economic success. Trust before the America's high trust society was relegated to relational and organizational trust levels at most, and this can be seen surmised by the apparent lack of trust for the institution of the federal government before World War 2 and the discrepancy of that lack of trust and approval of the governments actions as previously mentioned. It is normally far more likely to build and express trust to those that are closest personally and in similar communities and organizations, but the solidarity that arose created a necessary common identity that spurred on the development of further trust to move from a low trust society of the past to a high trust society of the present. However, as a consequence of moving to a high trust society, the effects of trust violations amplify and become much more damaging to trust than they were before which is a possible reason for why Americans seem so worried today that trust is degrading even when that high amount of trust was not the norm in the past. 79% of Americans think they have too little trust in each other today and 58% believe it that is important for that trust to be improved. Furthermore, 64% of Americans believe that this declining trust in the federal government is making it more difficult to solve problems (Raine & Perrin, 2019). These results

show that there is a present belief that trust is necessary for the federal government to function, whereas before the change in trust, that trust was assumed to not necessarily be needed.

The Persistence of Trust

Now the question turns to why there has been such an abrupt decline in both public and institutional trust and the answer to that lies with the persisting nature of trust. Expression of trust by individuals is affected by the fulfillment of expectations and violations of those expectations, and the Vietnam War period was based upon lies such as the Gulf of Tonkin incident that would set the tone of trust for the rest of the period. The continual lies violating trust rapidly degraded the institutional trust that had built the foundations for America's high trust society and public trust degraded as a result of this because as Kuwabara notes in their study on trust violations, "generalized trust played a significant role in American exchange relations" (Kuwabara et al., 2014). Yet, this trust degradation was localized to the institutional level of trust as trust in local government, which depends on organizational trust, remained and continues to remain at a consistently high level from past to present.

Notably, local and state government trust has remained steadily high when compared to the federal government, and the polls show the lowest point of local government trust being 63% in 1972 and the highest point with 77% in 1998. State governments fair considerably better than their federal counterpart as well with their lowest point occurring in 2009 with 55% trust and their highest point occurring in 1998 at 80% trust (Weinschenk & Helpap, 2015). The lack of any correlation between local and state trust, which can be categorized under organizational trust, to the federal government suggests that the impact of the trust violation in the federal government had mainly an upward effect in causing the decline of trust while lower stages of trust were mostly unaffected.

As for trust in other organization groups such as scientists, average trust towards the scientific community in general has remained stable since the 1970's likely due to the scope of the degradation of institutional trust propagating upward only, but a few organization groups such as medicine have also seen a steady decline which has been a cause for concern. The Pew Research Center's polls from the 1970's forward show a gradual but constant decline in trust for the medicine community ("Public Confidence in Scientists Has Remained Stable for Decades," 2020). A possible explanation is that the increasing costs of medical care has made people become more hesitant to seek medical care thereby separating them from the community of medicine leading to a gradual decline in trust as negative trust violations build with no positive trust interactions to counteract that. Considering the sets of data available on the topic from the CDC in the 2014 and 2016, there were 282 physician visits in 2014 as compared to in 2016 where that number decreased to 278 physician visits (Ashman et al., 2017, 2019). This decline is possibly an anomaly due to the small period between these findings, but it is concerning as the number should be growing as the United States' population is aging and expanding.

Diversity of High and Low Trust Societies

The United States is not alone in being a high trust society as the results of solidarity stemming from World War 2 was widespread for many of the participants in the war, and therefore the change in trust seems to not be unique to the United States. Examples of societies that have become high-trust societies are Denmark and Germany which see and rely on fairly high levels of public trust much like the United States, but the difference between the United States and these other high trust societies is that they are not facing a decline in their public trust. Instead, their public trust is growing. From 1981 to 2008, Denmark went from 51% of people saying "most people can be trusted" to 76% in 2008, and Germany also sees a slight increase

from 1989 to 2008 from 35% to 39%. These countries' growth of trust whereas the US has seen decline is significant in that they prove that that the decline of trust is not inevitability after transitioning to a high trust society. This means that the United States' decline of trust is almost certainly a result of trust violations that were only experienced in the United States such as those that occurred during the Vietnam War.

Despite the development of high trust in many societies, some cultures outside of the western cultural sphere have not so readily embraced institutional and public trust such as Japan. In recent polls, only 29.4% of people responded with a positive expression of trust towards their government, but despite this Japan has had a positive-neutral opinion of their prime minister's cabinet and therefor policies (Genron NPO, 2019; "Japan Political Pulse," 2020). This bears a strikingly similar resemblance to the situation in the United States before the development of trust happened in World War 2, and this suggests that Japan is currently in a similar trust stage as the United States was in the past focusing primarily on relational and organizational trust. Kuwabara notes that the lack of development towards public trust may be in large part due to the cultural differences between Japan and the United States where one is highly collective with strong social networks and the other emphasizes individualism with high social mobility and less stability in relationships (Kuwabara et al., 2014). A collective society has less of a need for public and institutional trust because the strong and highly structured relational ties with other individuals and organizations provide avenues of support already similar to what public and institutional trust provide. Furthermore, this strong trust network may support interactions towards strangers similar to those that public trust would provide because of the lessened repercussions of having trust breached. This pseudo-public trust may also be one of the factors

explaining the juxtaposition of politeness and kindness with the intense in-grouping and out-grouping between individuals.

Consequences of Modern Trust

Trust's development due to the solidarity achieved during World War 2 and the consequent establishment of a high trust society and reliance on trust due to that within the United States has made it substantially more influential to interactions today than in the past as the scope of towards who and how trust is expressed has widened. The different types of trust intertwine now more than ever as the American reliance on the emotion increases. This can both be a good or bad thing depending on how trust is chosen to be used. If trust is handled as an asset to grow and invest into, then the prospects of positive cooperation and goodwill increase as that trust lubricates the social interactions between all parties of trust generating prosperity. However, if trust is treated as a resource to be used up, then short-term gains by expending trust through trust violations are followed by rapidly worsening quality of cooperative interactions. From the polls on and actions of the United States' federal government, it is clear that the United States federal government has chosen to pursue the latter of these two options to its own detriment which has led to the current crisis of institutional trust that is faced today.

This ongoing crisis of trust is the current result of the change in trust and progression into a high trust society. However, it does not need to be remain that way. Trust is complex emotion and there is a clear course of action to remedy this crisis. Just as trust can be lost through infringing on expectations, it can be regained by following through with promises. As stated before, trust is a continuous emotion built over time and influenced by historical interactions. It knows no limits and knows no bounds. Though it may seem futile to reverse course on the crisis of trust, which has seemingly prevailed for decades, it must be remembered that decades of time

are but only a small fraction of history even with regards to the young United States. The future consequences of trust in American society depend solely on the actions of the present, and that very same future begins today.

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